



THE LITTLE REWRITES

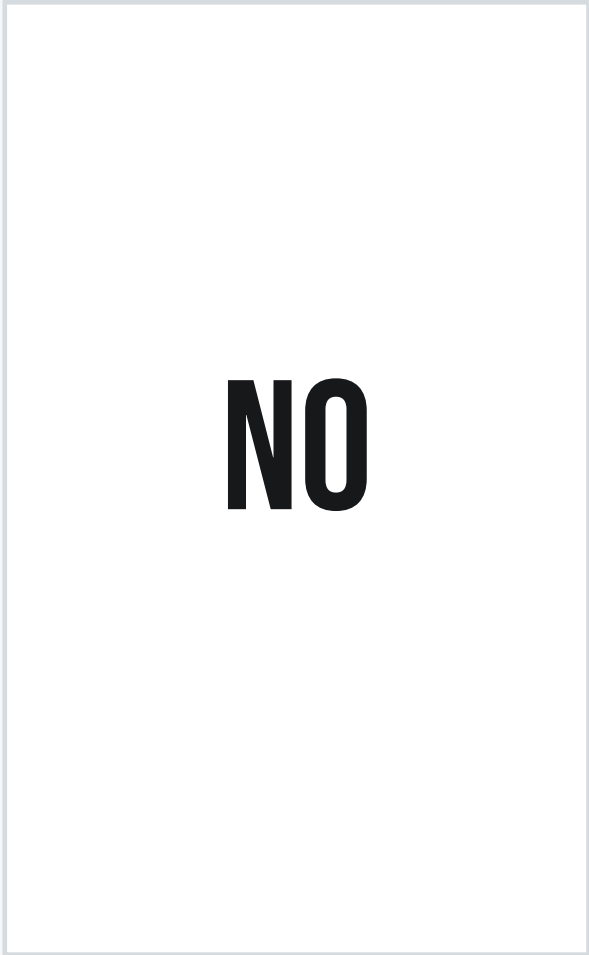
THE GIRL WHO LOVED GRAY

A picture book about all the colors between yes and no.

MK PARRISH

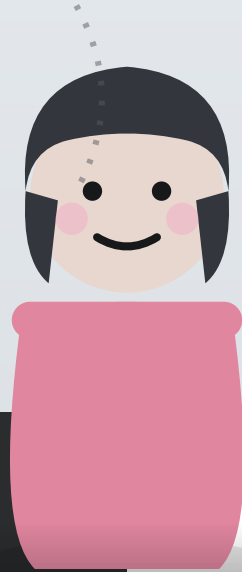


YES



NO

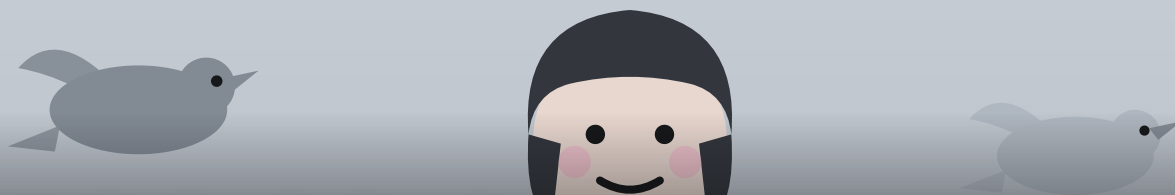
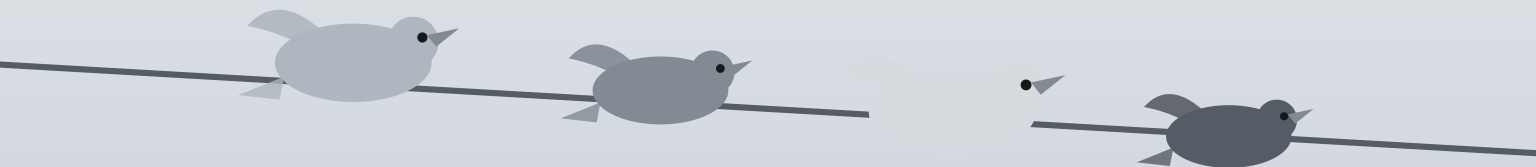
They will tell you the world comes in two colors. Black, and white. Yes or no. Good or bad. Pick a side, they say — *quickly.*



Marlowe tried. She really did. But standing on the hard white line, with the hard black line beside it, something in her felt tight, and small, and not quite true.



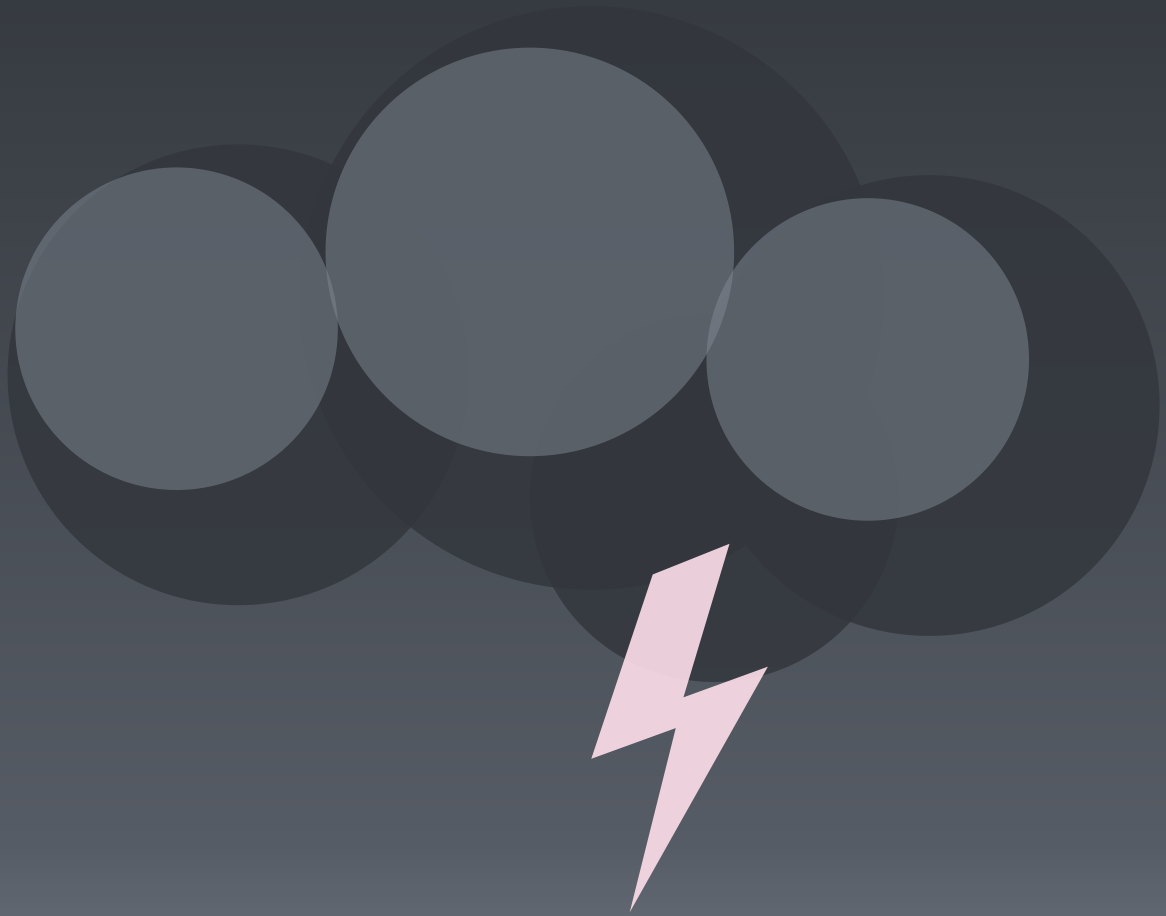
Then, one gray morning, the fog came. It rolled down the hills like a slow, soft breath and swallowed the sharp edges of everything. Marlowe stepped in, and the fog held her like a secret.



In the fog she found gray. Not one gray —
hundreds. Dove gray and smoke gray, the gray
of old silver, the gray of a pigeon's wing
catching the light.



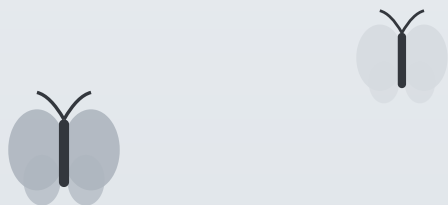
Rain came next, tapping its gray fingers on the glass. The whole street went soft and shining and pewter. She pressed her nose to the window and breathed the cool, wet gray of it.



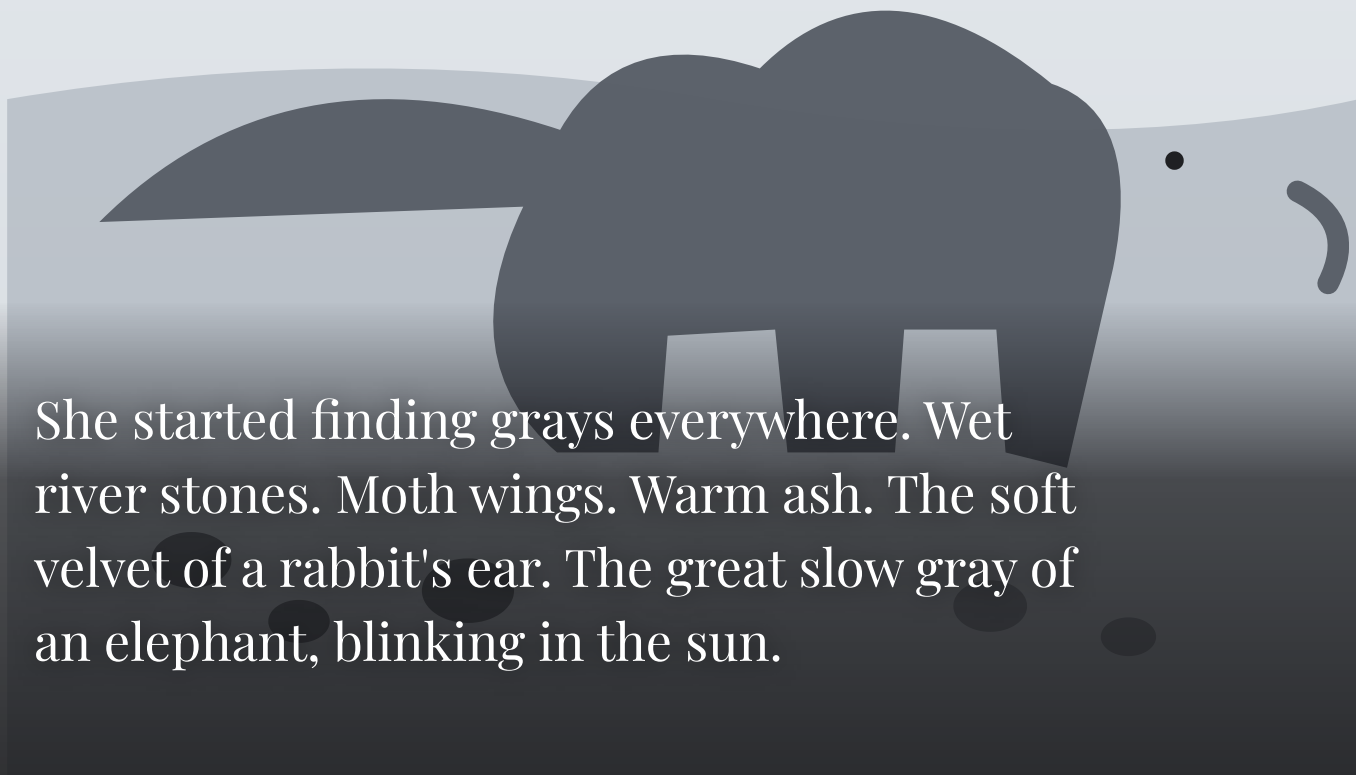
A storm stacked its clouds like slate. Not scary
— *enormous*. Alive. Thunder rolled somewhere
far and gentle, and the sky was every gray at
once.

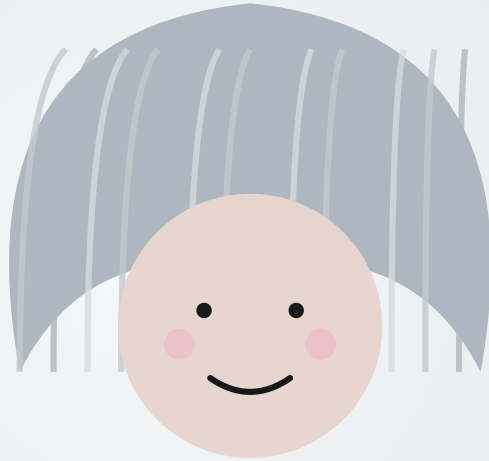


And at the end of the day she found the best
gray of all — twilight. The hour that is neither
day nor night, when the world holds its breath
between two things and is lovely in both.

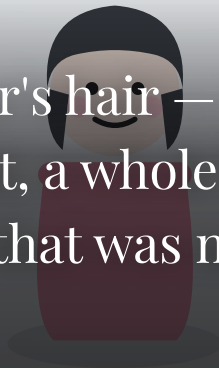


She started finding grays everywhere. Wet river stones. Moth wings. Warm ash. The soft velvet of a rabbit's ear. The great slow gray of an elephant, blinking in the sun.



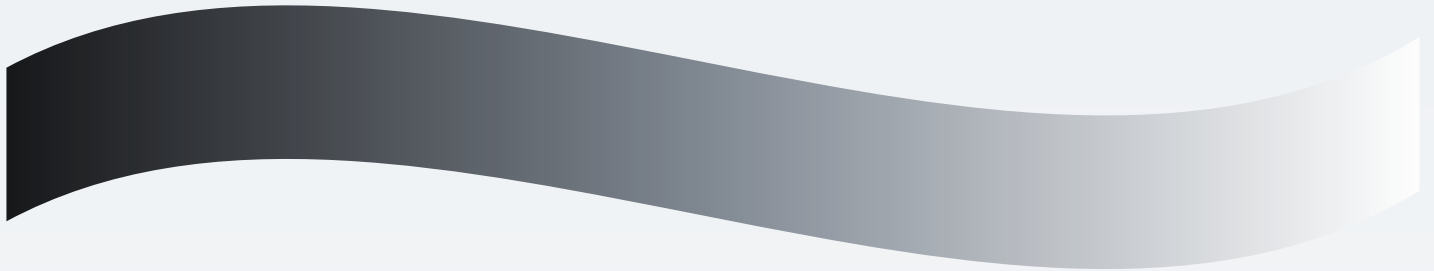


And her grandmother's hair — silver and
smoke and moonlight, a whole life of grays.
Every strand a story that was neither all happy
nor all sad.

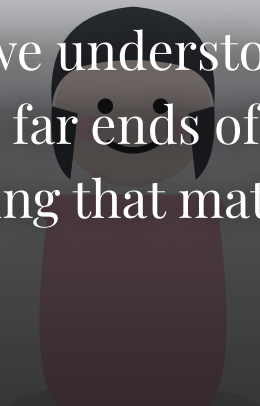


BLACK

WHITE

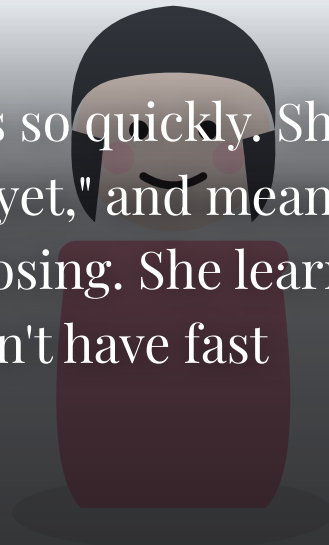


That was when Marlowe understood. Black and white are only the two far ends of a long, soft ribbon — and everything that matters lives in the gray in between.





So she stopped picking sides so quickly. She learned to say, "I'm not sure yet," and mean it like a door opening — not closing. She learned to love the questions that don't have fast answers.





The world is not black and white, little one—
no matter who tells you it is. It is dove and
pewter, smoke and silver, storm and twilight.
It is gray. And gray is where the whole
beautiful truth lives. *Go and love it.*

FOR THE GROWN-UP READING ALONG

We hand children a black-and-white world early: right and wrong, smart and dumb, winner and loser, us and them. It is faster to think that way, and lonelier, and mostly untrue. This book is a small argument for the gray — for nuance, for "it depends," for holding two true things at once, for the patience to stay in a question a little longer.

When you finish, look for a gray together. A pigeon. A rain cloud. The soft middle of an argument that isn't all one person's fault. Then say the sentence that undoes a lifetime of hard lines: *"Two things can be true at the same time."*